

Romans

The Obedience of Faith

Chapter 12-16

<https://tinyurl.com/RomeGospel>

<https://tinyurl.com/TeachTheWord>

Faith, Hope, and Love

The Outline - Review

ROMANS – Concentric Outline

- A 1:1–17 Gospel (Obedience of Faith)
- B 1:18–3:20 Humanity under sin
 - C 3:21–5:21 Justification
 - D 6–8 New life in Christ
 - E 9–11 Israel and God's purposes
 - D' 12–13 New life practiced
 - C' 14–15 Justification lived in community
- B' 15:14–33 Gospel ministry
- A' 16 Doxology (Ex: Obedience of Faith)

Purposes of the Gospel

The Obedience of Faith

*“Through him we have received grace and **our apostleship to bring about the obedience of faith** among all the Gentiles on behalf of his name.” (Romans 1:5)*

*“...but now is disclosed, and through the prophetic scriptures has been made known to all the nations, according to the command of the eternal God, **to bring about the obedience of faith**” (Romans 16:26)*

What is “the Obedience of Faith”? Possibilities...

1. **Obedience that comes from Faith (fruit?)**
 1. The obedience that faith produces.
2. **Obedience which consists of Faith (ingredient?)**
 1. *“But not all have obeyed the good news...” (Romans 10:16)*
3. **Faithful Obedience (different?)**
 1. *“The righteous by faith will live.” (Romans 1:17)*

What did Obedience of the Law produce?

What does Obedience of Faith produce?

Romans suggests that faith and obedience are inseparable aspects of the same response to God.

Notice how Paul frames the entire letter:

“through whom we have received grace and our apostleship to bring about the obedience of faith among all the Gentiles...” (Romans 1:5, NET)

And at the conclusion:

“...according to the command of the eternal God to bring about the obedience of faith.” (Romans 16:26, NET)

This phrase forms an inclusio around the entire epistle. Paul begins and ends Romans with “the obedience of faith.”

That means Romans itself should probably be read through this lens.

“Look, the one whose desires are not upright will faint from exhaustion, but the person of integrity will live because of his faithfulness.” (**Habakkuk 2:4**)

“For the righteousness of God is revealed in the gospel from faith to faith, just as it is written, “***The righteous by faith will live.*”**” (**Romans 1:17**)

What is “the obedience of faith”?

There are several possibilities.

1. Obedience that comes from faith

This is the most common Protestant interpretation.

- *Faith is the root.*
- *Obedience is the fruit.*

The meaning becomes:

- “the obedience that faith produces.”

This is true, but I think Romans says more.

2. Obedience which consists of faith

Paul sometimes speaks of believing as an act of obedience.

- For example:
- “But not all have obeyed the good news...” (Romans 10:16)

Paul then quotes Isaiah:

- “Lord, who has believed our report?”

Notice the parallel:

- Obeyed the gospel.
- Believed the message.

To refuse faith is to disobey.

To believe is to obey.

In this sense, *faith itself is an act of submission to God's testimony.*

3. Faithful obedience

This may come closest to Habakkuk's original meaning.

- The Hebrew *emunah* often means:
- *faithfulness*
- *fidelity*
- *steadfast loyalty*

Thus the righteous person is not merely someone who trusts God intellectually.

He is someone whose trust expresses itself in faithful allegiance.

The distinction is subtle but important.

- Biblical faith is not merely believing that God exists.
- It is entrusting oneself to Him.
- And entrusting oneself necessarily changes one's conduct.

The Just Shall Live by Faith

Reconsidering Habakkuk 2:4

“Look, the one whose desires are not upright will faint from exhaustion, but the person of integrity will live because of his faithfulness.” (Habakkuk 2:4)

*“For the righteousness of God is revealed in the gospel from faith to faith, just as it is written, **“The righteous by faith will live.”**” (Romans 1:17)*

Faithful Obedience

This may come closest to Habakkuk’s original meaning.

- faithfulness
- fidelity
- steadfast loyalty

The Just shall live by a believing loyalty.

Habakkuk’s contrast is between:

- the proud soul
- the faithful soul
- The proud man follows himself.
- The righteous man follows God.

Thus, faith and obedience are not two separate categories.

- They are two perspectives on the same reality.

The Just Shall Live by Faith, and the Unjust Chaldeans Will Die (2:4)

Because the **soul** of the king of Babylon was lifted up with pride, he would die, but the godly remnant of Israel would **live by . . . faith**. Verse 4c is quoted three times in the NT. The three parts of the verse—the just—shall live—by faith, go well with the emphases of the three contexts where they appear: [Rom 1:17](#) emphasizes "the just"; [Gal 3:11](#) emphasizes "faith"; [Heb 10:38](#) emphasizes "shall live." The literal rendering in Habakkuk's context, is "By his faith the just shall live." It could also be paraphrased "the justified-by-faith-one shall live."

Reconsidering Habakkuk 2:4

I would now revise the summary of Habakkuk’s influence.

Previously I emphasized:

- The Just shall live by faith.

Now I would emphasize:

- The Just shall live by faithful trust.

Or perhaps:

- The Just shall live by believing loyalty.

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The Just Shall Live by Faith

God's Reconsidering Romans 12-16

Instead of asking:

- What does faith produce?

Paul may be asking:

- What does faith look like when lived?

Romans 12

- Faith presents itself as a living sacrifice.
- Faith serves.
- Faith loves.
- Faith blesses enemies.

These are not additions to faith. They are faith embodied.

Romans 13

- Faith submits to God's ordained authority.
- Faith pays its obligations.
- Faith loves its neighbor.

Again, this is not faith plus obedience. This is faith expressing its true nature.

The Just Shall Live by Faith

God's Reconsidering Romans 12-16

Romans 14

- Faith respects conscience.
- Faith refuses to judge fellow servants of God.
- Faith trusts God enough to leave judgment in His hands.

Romans 15

- Faith bears the weak.
- Faith sacrifices personal rights.
- Faith seeks unity.

Romans 16

- Faith remains loyal to apostolic truth.
- Faith recognizes faithful laborers.
- Faith rejects false teaching.

Romans 12-16 is not merely a list of consequences that happen after faith. It is a description of faith itself in action.

The Obedience of Faith

Israel's Failure Revisited (Romans 9-11)

Many readers frame the issue as:

- Israel pursued works.
- Gentiles pursued faith.

Paul's point seems deeper.

- Israel often sought covenant blessing while resisting God's word.

Consider **Romans 10:16**:

- *"But not all have obeyed the good news."*

Again, Paul equates believing and obeying.

- The fundamental issue was not merely a lack of intellectual faith.
- It was a refusal to submit to God's righteousness.
- *"For ignoring the righteousness that comes from God, and seeking instead to establish their own righteousness, they did not submit to God's righteousness." (Romans 10:3)*

What is the opposite of faith? Unbelief?

Israel's Failure Revisited

This adjustment is especially important in Romans 9-11.

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- "But not all have obeyed the good news."

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(Romans 10:3, NET)

Notice the key word: **submit**.

- The opposite of faith is not merely unbelief.
- The opposite of faith is self-rule.
- This fits **Habakkuk** perfectly.
- *The proud man trusts himself.*
- *The righteous man entrusts himself to God.*

The Obedience of Faith

God's Romans, Galatians, and Hebrews Revisited

With “*the obedience of faith*” in view, the three books become even more unified.

Romans

- Who are the righteous?
- Those who have submitted to God's righteousness through faithful trust.

Galatians

- What is obedient faith?
- Not merely belief.
- Faith working through love (**Galatians 5:6**).
- Faithful allegiance to Christ rather than reliance on fleshly achievement.

Hebrews

- What does it mean to live by faith?
- Persevering loyalty.
- The heroes of **Hebrews 11** did not merely hold correct beliefs.
- They obeyed.
- Their faith was visible because it acted.

Hebrews

What does it mean to live by faith?

- Persevering loyalty.

The heroes of Hebrews 11 did not merely hold correct beliefs.

They obeyed.

- Noah built.
- Abraham left.
- Moses chose.
- Israel crossed.
- Rahab received.

Their faith was visible because it acted.

Conclusion

God's Purposes Will not Fail

If Romans is framed by “*the obedience of faith*” (1:5; 16:26), then **Romans 12-16** should not primarily be viewed as a section on works that follow faith.

Rather, it is Paul's portrait of what faith actually is.

- The faith that justifies is not mere mental assent.
- It is trusting submission to God.
- It is believing allegiance to Christ.
- It is the kind of faith that offers the body as a living sacrifice, loves enemies, submits to God-ordained authority, serves fellow believers, bears the weak, preserves unity, and remains faithful to the gospel.

In that sense, **Habakkuk 2:4**, **Romans 1:5**, and **Romans 12-16** all converge on a single idea:

The righteous person lives by a faith that obeys because it trusts, and trusts because it has surrendered itself to God. Faith and obedience are not rivals in Paul's thought; they are inseparable expressions of covenant loyalty to the God who saves.